A SUMMARY OF THE ENTIRE HILCHOT SHABBAT IN 14 CLASSES

The Shabbat Kitchen Part 2: Shehiyah, Hazara and Hatmana

Class 4 of 14

Series: Laws of Shabbat — a 14-part course

Shiur: 4 of 14

Topic: The Shabbat Kitchen, Part 2 — She'hiyah, Hazara and Hatmana (hotplates, blechs, urns, crockpots)

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Recap of Bishul

- **Bishul** — transforming food with the power of **fire**, as in the Mishkan. Cooking directly in the **sun** is permitted; cooking in something **heated by the sun** is rabbinically forbidden (an onlooker assumes it came off the fire).
- A **kli rishon** — even off the fire — still cooks while above 45°C. In a **kli sheni** there is strictly no Bishul, apart from a few tender foods (eggs, perhaps tea).
- No problem of **bishul after afiyah** or vice versa — croutons may go into soup (for Ashkenazim too if a ladle was used).
- **Reheating:** solids may be reheated (*ein bishul achar bishul be'davar yavesh*) — their main purpose, being edible, remains. Liquids, once cooled below **yad soledet bo (45°C)**, may not be reheated.

Part A — Completing Bishul

A solid dish with some liquid

Salmon cooked before Shabbat in a sauce, taken from the fridge: solid or liquid? **Chacham Ovadia Yosef**: follow how the dish is **called**. We call it "salmon" (with some sauce for taste), not "sauce with salmon" — so it is a **solid** and may be reheated. But a very **watery cholent** or a stew that is more liquid than solid counts as a liquid and may not be reheated.

Asking a non-Jew to reheat a liquid

Normally what is forbidden to us may not be asked of a non-Jew. But many great authorities — including the **Rambam** — hold there is no Bishul in reheating an already-cooked liquid. Although we don't follow them, on the strength of their view **one may directly ask a non-Jew** (e.g. an au pair) to reheat soup that was fully cooked (boiled) before Shabbat and has since cooled — no need even to hint.

Eating in a home where Bishul isn't kept

For many melachot there is a **penalty (*knas*)**: one may not benefit on Shabbat from something done in a forbidden way — even if done in error, and even by a guest who did nothing — so as not to encourage, even implicitly, the breaking of Shabbat. Food cooked (or finished cooking) on Shabbat may not be eaten **on Shabbat**; after Shabbat it may be eaten (if done unintentionally).

- If you know or strongly suspect your host does not keep the laws of Bishul — that is a serious problem; if already invited, consult a rabbinic authority.
- This applies to **Bishul**, which changes the food's essence. Laws like **Borer** (selecting) don't change the food itself — so eating where the host may not know the details of Borer is fine.

Part B — She'hiyah: Leaving Food on the Fire into Shabbat

The principle — and the rabbinic exception

Anything set going before Shabbat may continue into Shabbat: a **garden sprinkler** switched on at 3:45 may water all Shabbat; **timers** may switch lights on and off. By the same logic, a raw piece of meat put on at 3:30 to cook through Shabbat should be fine from the Torah — and it is.

But Chazal knew human nature — especially our love of Shabbat food. You come home from shul at 5, guests arrive at 5:30, and the meat needs two more hours… You may be tempted to **turn up the flame** — two Torah prohibitions at once:

1. **Bishul** — speeding up cooking (*megis*).
2. **Mav'ir** — kindling: raising a flame is like lighting one.

In Talmudic times this meant stoking the coals. So Chazal forbade leaving food on the fire into Shabbat unless it has reached a certain stage.

How cooked must it be?

A major debate in the Gemara and poskim:

- One view: **fully cooked**.
- The other: **ma'achal ben Derusai** — edible in a pinch, roughly **half-cooked**. (Ben Derusai was a highwayman always on the move, who ate his food half-cooked.) Once half-cooked, there is no fear you will tamper to finish it.

The halacha follows the second view: once food is half-cooked before Shabbat, it may be left on even an **uncovered flame** to finish cooking overnight or until morning.

Winter warning: in summer, food put on at 7 is ready long before a 9 pm Shabbat. In midwinter, with Shabbat at 3:35–4:00, food put on at 3 for a 5:30 meal may **not** be half-cooked when Shabbat begins — then it may not be left as is.

The blech

Chazal permitted less-than-half-cooked food if the **coals were covered** — a clear sign that you've taken your mind off the fire. That is the origin of the **blech**: a sheet of metal covering

the flame as a reminder not to touch the fire. If food is already half-cooked (and you won't return food during Shabbat), you don't need a blech.

- **Covering the dials:** today one raises the heat with the knobs, not the coals, so some cover the dials too (some blechs bend over them). Strictly, **not necessary** — the sign belongs on the place of the fire.
- **Hotplates:** modern hotplates in England have **no dial** — a fixed temperature you cannot change. So food — even less than half-cooked — may be left to cook on a hotplate from before Shabbat. (Old hotplates with dials would be a problem.)
- Gas or electric makes no difference.

The urn

The same rule applies to **liquids**. Fill the urn early enough — at least half an hour before Shabbat (more for a big urn) — so the water reaches **at least 45°C** ("half-cooked") by Shabbat. Better still, **fully boiled**: if you take water out while it is still heating (say at 75°C), the smaller remaining volume will heat faster — you've indirectly sped up the boiling. If only at 45°C at Shabbat, don't draw from it until it has fully boiled.

Stuck with no blech or hotplate

- Make a **makeshift blech** from several folded layers of aluminium foil (one sheet is not substantial enough).
- **Question from the floor:** no foil — can you put an empty pot on the flame and the food pot inside or on top of it? — **Yes**, excellent: it serves as the sign, as long as there is a gap.
- If nothing is available and Shabbat is minutes away — seek rabbinic guidance. Some argue the decree doesn't apply to a **steady modern flame**: Chazal feared stoking coals that die down; a gas flame doesn't fade. We don't follow this, but it is a significant opinion for someone stranded.

Part C — Hazara: Returning Food to the Fire on Shabbat

From the Torah, putting a fully cooked schnitzel into a pot on a lit flame on Shabbat is no problem — solids aren't re-cooked and no flame is being adjusted. Chazal forbade it for two reasons:

1. **Mechzei ke'mevashel** — it looks just like weekday cooking (fridge → pot → fire).
2. You may be tempted to **turn up the flame** to reheat it faster.

This applies even to food that was on the fire when Shabbat began but was taken off and has cooled.

Returning food to a blech — two conditions

1. **The flame is covered** (blech, foil) — a sign against tampering, and not the normal way of cooking.
2. **Continuity** — the food was taken off *intending to return it* and not put down somewhere that breaks the connection (e.g. **the fridge** or the floor). Off the blech, onto the table, serve, back on — fine. Into the fridge and back — a new act, forbidden even with a blech.

Hotplates — a different category

Neither concern applies to a dial-less hotplate: you can't raise the temperature, and it doesn't look like cooking — it's even called a *"plata shel Shabbat"*. So with a hotplate there is **no Hazara problem at all**:

- A **solid** (or a mostly-solid dish like salmon in sauce) may be taken **straight from the fridge** and put on the hotplate — directly on the plate too.
- Challah may be warmed on the hotplate (but not placed fresh on a blech).
- **Liquids:** the issue isn't Hazara but Bishul — a cooled liquid may not be reheated. Soup taken off to serve and returned while still above 45°C is fine.

Reheating cold soup yourself — the timer method

- Ask a non-Jew to put the cold (pre-cooked) soup on the hotplate — or even a blech (not a naked flame).
- Or: if the hotplate is on a **timer and currently off**, you may place the pre-cooked, cooled soup on it; when the timer switches on, it heats by itself (Chacham Ovadia — explicit). E.g. put it on at 8:30 before shul for an 11 o'clock lunch. **Only for food already cooked** — never raw food.
- Q: If the hotplate went off at 11 and comes back on at 12, may you put the soup on while it's still warm? — Only if the soup is **below 45°C**; above that, it would be cooking.

Part D — Hatmana: Insulating Food

Wrapping to retain heat

Without a hotplate, people used to boil the food just before Shabbat and **wrap the pot in towels** — big pots stay hot for four or five hours (a common practice in Israel). Chazal forbade **fully wrapping** food **on Shabbat itself**, even with something that only **retains** heat (*davar she'eino mosif hevel*) — because one naturally heats food up before wrapping it, and so may come to cook or kindle.

- Wrapping **before** Shabbat with something that only retains heat — **permitted**.
- Only **full** wrapping is forbidden. Leaving one side open, or a tea towel just **on top**, is fine.
- Wrapping in something that **adds** heat (*davar ha'mosif hevel*) — e.g. burying a pot in coals — is forbidden **even before Shabbat**.

Crockpots

A crockpot's element surrounds the pot — seemingly *hatmana* in something that adds heat, forbidden even from before Shabbat; some do not allow crockpots for this reason. But the halacha is that **we may use crockpots**. Among the reasons: a pot's own **lid** is not considered wrapping (otherwise one could never put a lid on), and the crockpot has only that single lid — but one should not put anything further on top of it. To satisfy all views, place **two balls of aluminium foil** between the pot and the heating element, creating a gap.

Thermos flasks and hot-water bottles

Both are permitted — including filling them from the urn on Shabbat. Hatmana applies only to a **kli rishon**; once water is poured into a flask or bottle it is a kli sheni, with far less concern

that one will heat it first. Likewise, hot water poured into a pan may be wrapped.

Summary

- A mostly-**solid** dish (salmon in sauce) may be reheated; a watery stew may not. A non-Jew may be asked to reheat cooled soup.
- Food cooked on Shabbat may not be eaten on Shabbat — beware hosts who don't keep Bishul (not an issue for Borer).
- **She'hiyah:** food left on from before Shabbat must be at least **half-cooked** — or on a **blech** or dial-less **hotplate**. Fill the urn early; ideally fully boiled.
- **Hazara:** returning food to a blech needs a covered flame and continuity (not via the fridge). On a **hotplate** any cooked **solid** may go on, even from the fridge; cooled liquids only via a non-Jew or a hotplate on a timer that is off.
- **Hatmana:** don't fully wrap a kli rishon on Shabbat; before Shabbat is fine with heat-retaining wraps. Crockpots permitted (ideally with foil balls); thermos flasks and hot-water bottles permitted.

Coming Up

Shiur 5 — 20 November: The Shabbat Kitchen, Part 3 — Threshing and Selecting

- *Dash* — peeling and squeezing fruit and vegetables: orange juice, lemon on salad or in tea
- Ice cubes, freezing water, using soap; milking
- *Borer* — selecting: bones in fish and chicken, setting the table on Friday night for Shabbat lunch

B'Ezrat Hashem

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